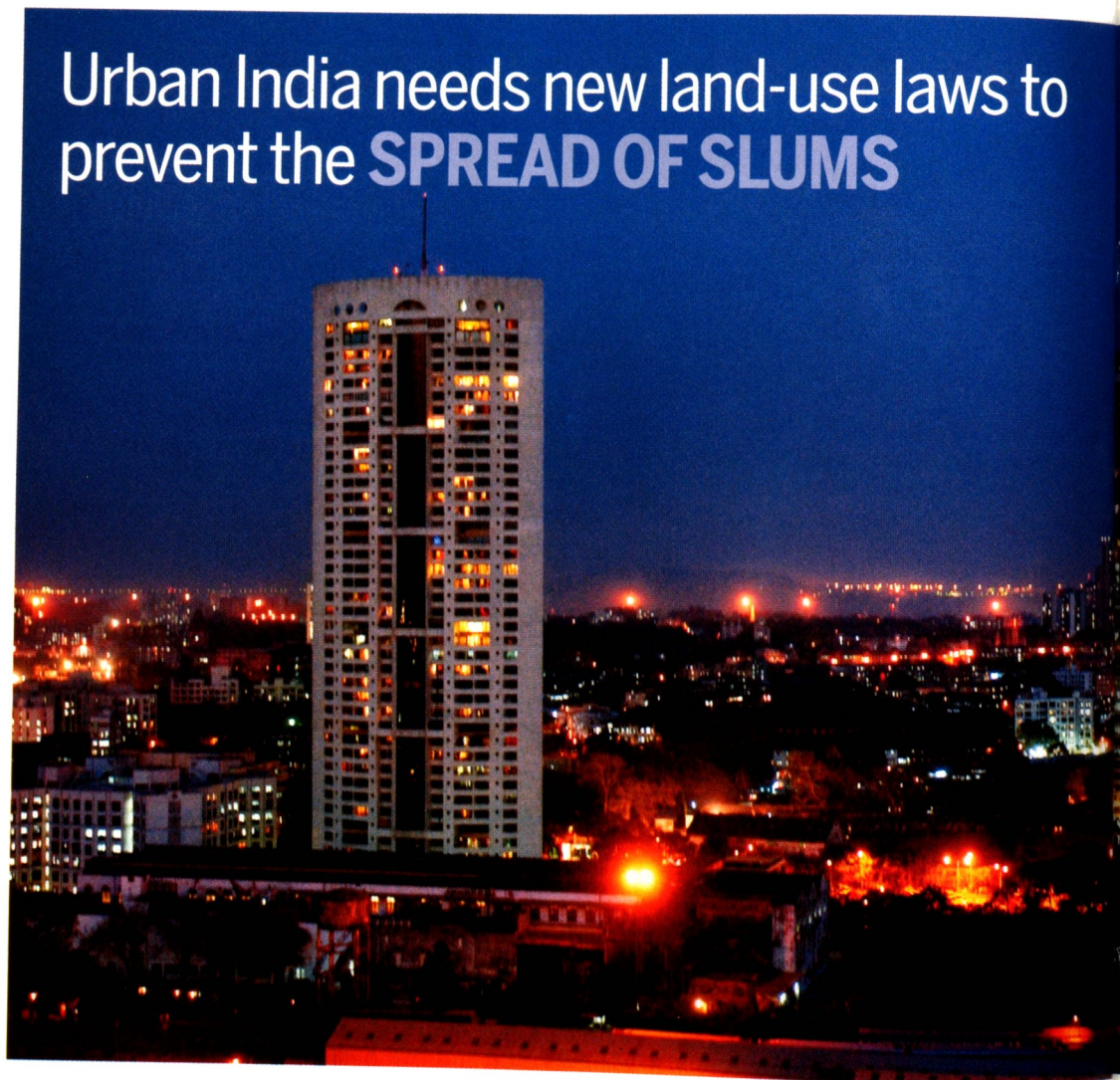


Urban India needs new land-use laws to prevent the **SPREAD OF SLUMS**



Cities are as old as settled human history. This is abundantly clear in South Asia, with Harappa and Mohenjodaro being early indigenous examples and Varanasi representing a living embodiment of this tradition. In contrast, however, pervasive, large-scale urbanisation is a very recent phenomenon. Estimates put the total urban population of the world in

1900 at around 250 million, less than India's urban population today. Over the course of the 20th century, urbanisation became increasingly widespread. Today, in 2008, half of humanity lives in urban settlements. Barring a major catastrophe, cities and towns represent the future. They cannot be wished away.

While geography and other physical endowments clearly matter, increasing urban share of population has been associated with